Head of AI & Automation

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CANDIDATE THESIS

Make growth load-bearing.

Build the operating layer beneath AI: field truth, explicit ownership, continuous data, governed system joints, and decision surfaces that improve the work instead of adding reporting burden.

Actual mandate

Turn fragmented estimating, project, field, document, and financial workflows into a scalable operating system that removes duplicate handling, preserves scope and evidence across handoffs, and gives leaders trusted visibility.

Why now

The supplied role description points to rapid growth, national operations, and a first-in-function builder role. Public company materials emphasize nationwide projects, efficient operations, precise scoping, budgeting, phasing, and turnkey execution.

FOUR TENSIONS TO MANAGE

Tension	Operating answer
Quick wins vs durable foundation	Prototype narrowly; productionize only with ownership, data, controls, support, and measurable outcomes.
Standard core vs field variation	Standardize records, accountability, and interfaces while preserving legitimate regional, project, and customer differences.
Executive visibility vs frontline usefulness	Make reporting the exhaust of better work; never require a second update solely for the dashboard.
AI opportunity vs deterministic control	Use AI for language, ambiguity, and bounded judgment; keep rules, approvals, and financial controls deterministic where they should be.

STAKEHOLDER TOPOLOGY

Executive sponsors

President, COO, CFO, national and regional operations leadership. Their concern: scalable growth, reliable visibility, economics, and risk.

Workflow owners

Estimating, procurement, project management, closeout, AR/AP, sales, and office administration. Their concern: less chase, clearer ownership, fewer duplicate steps.

Frontline users

Construction managers, operations managers, foremen, project coordinators, and field teams. Their concern: tools that fit the work and function under real conditions.

Technical ecosystem

NetSuite, Microsoft 365, field applications, vendors, implementation partners, security, and support. Their concern: interfaces, permissions, reliability, maintainability, and change control.

INDEPENDENT CANDIDATE BRIEF · DELAWARE VALLEY COMPANIES

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THE LOAD-BEARING WORKFLOW

Each candidate workflow is evaluated as a structure, not a tool request. All five layers must bear weight before scale.

Layer	Question	Production evidence
1 · Field truth	How does the work actually happen, including exceptions and informal coordination?	Observed workflow, artifacts, timing, exception examples, user burden.
2 · Work ownership	Who decides, approves, maintains, resolves, and owns the outcome?	Decision rights, escalation path, service owner, business outcome owner.
3 · Data continuity	What record is authoritative and what evidence must survive each handoff?	Required fields, source systems, quality rules, retention, traceability.
4 · System joints	How will NetSuite, Microsoft 365, and field tools exchange information reliably?	Interface contract, permissions, logging, retry/recovery, support runbook.
5 · Decision surface	What decision becomes faster or better, and where can AI assist safely?	Dashboard/alert/assistant, human authority, baseline, adoption and reliability measures.

FIRST WORKFLOW HYPOTHESIS: ESTIMATE TO READY PROJECT

Observed risk to test

Estimate logic, scope boundaries, attachments, exclusions, customer commitments, and internal ownership may lose fidelity or require duplicate entry during award-to-project conversion.

First mechanism

A structured handoff record that creates or updates the project workspace, carries accountable evidence, flags missing conditions, and makes exceptions visible before execution begins.

Do not automate yet

Judgment about ambiguous scope, customer negotiation, commercial risk, and field feasibility remains with accountable humans.

Measure from baseline

Handoff completeness, rekeying events, elapsed time, unresolved scope exceptions, project-start delays, and retained use.

BALANCED SCORECARD

Dimension	Measures
Flow	Cycle time, waiting time, exception age, work-in-process.
Economics	Labor hours avoided, rework, unbilled approved work, preventable delay.
Quality and trust	Completeness, data reconciliation, traceability, override/error rates.
Adoption	Retained use, workflow completion, fallback behavior, user effort.
Learning speed	Time to bounded test, issue-to-improvement cycle, reusable patterns created.

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EVIDENCE MAP

Role need	Verified evidence	Transferability
Hands-on operating automation	Vape-Jet AI-first transformation across ERP, production, purchasing, quality, support, engineering issue flow, telemetry, and workflows.	Current direct work across the same kind of messy cross-functional boundaries.
AI/workflow design	DudeWorth readiness frameworks and agentic patterns with retrieval, human authority, evaluation, escalation, and governance.	Disciplined use-case selection and production-readiness reasoning.
Scaled operations	Amazon Prime Pittsburgh launch and mechanisms supporting approximately five million second-day orders annually.	Operating cadence, visibility, standard work, escalation, and customer-backward metrics.
Engineering and controls	Compunetics leadership across engineering, manufacturing, quality, delivery, root cause, measures, and process controls.	High-reliability systems thinking and technical/business translation.
Distributed/field work	Cardinal remote regional operation; ZeusVu regulated field systems, GIS, chain-of-custody, and 100% safety record.	Remote operations, field evidence, logistics, adoption, and consequence-aware execution.

STRONGEST HIRING OBJECTION

No direct paving tenure; no unverified NetSuite or Graph ownership.

The campaign owns the gap. The case rests on adjacent evidence, on-site discovery, hands-on operating-system work, programming/data fluency, ERP modernization, and a credible technical learning plan - not on keyword substitution.

EXECUTIVE QUESTIONS

1. Where does awarded work most often lose scope, assumptions, or evidence before delivery?
2. Which numbers are challenged because source, timing, or ownership is unclear?
3. Which manual step creates the most downstream exceptions?
4. Where do teams maintain a second truth outside the authoritative system?
5. What must remain locally flexible across projects, offices, and customers?
6. What would make the first automation undeniably useful to estimators and project managers?
7. Where should AI assist judgment, and where should deterministic workflow remain the default?
8. What is the strongest reason a prior systems change did not stick?

PUBLIC-SOURCE GROUNDING

Official company sources reviewed: Delaware Valley Paving home, team, locations, careers, national services, and current capital-planning content. The role description and recruiter location thread were supplied by Russell. Company-specific workflow ideas are hypotheses for discovery, not claims about undisclosed internal processes.